The Middle East has been of huge importance in human history. It includes the two areas of oldest human civilisation: that along the Nile in Egypt and the area between the two rivers, the Tigris and the Euphrates, in today's Iraq. It is also the birthplace of three major world religions: Judaism, Christianity and Islam. The area at the centre of the Middle East (Israel/Palestine) is often referred to as the 'Holy Land'.

In the past hundred years, the Middle East has most commonly been associated with conflict, often over land or oil, and who controls it. Much of this strife has arisen over the creation of the Jewish state of Israel out of the land of Palestine in 1948. Since then there have been several wars between Israel and its Arab neighbours. Today, the conflict between Israel and the Palestinian Arabs remains at the core of so many crises in the Middle East.

The Arab–Israeli conflict is the main focus of this book but it also examines:

- Arab nationalism, especially in Egypt and Syria
- the Islamic revolution in Iran in 1979
- the causes and consequences of three wars involving Iraq
- the growth of political Islam and Islamic fundamentalism.